‘What’s this?’ he asked Unni.

Unni explained, but the auditor insisted it was outside the rule book. Unni asked him what he should do with the money now.

‘Deposit it back into the bank,’ the auditor barked.

Unni explained the rule that didn’t allow us to deposit money, only withdraw.

‘Then send it to India,’ the auditor said.

Unni said it was not possible unless there is a written instruction to do so.

By now the auditor was fuming: I had denied him the pleasure of being chauffeured from the railway station, and left him with an office assistant who had the temerity to speak back to the officer from the Indian Embassy. The auditor left in a huff.

I don’t know what report he submitted to the government, but I did report to Seshan the overbearing attitude of the auditor. Seshan asked me why I made an issue with the auditor. I replied that it was him, not me who made an issue. Later, Seshan told me that I did the right thing. ‘You don’t know much about bureaucracy, but your way of dealing with him worked. Or else these guys would road-roll you,’ he said.